which saw the queen as a heroine ruined by passion. For a brief overview of the afterlife of Cleopatra, Tyldesley (2008): 205–17.

25. Ibid.: 7–8. Joyce Tyldesley's very readable account of Cleopatra's life and times is upfront about the lack of primary material: 'Given these limitations of evidence it is clearly never going to be possible to write a conventional biography of Cleopatra; there are simply too many important details missing' (p. 7).

26. Cherry (2007): 7.

27. The names of prominent historical figures, ranging from Cleopatra to Mahatma Gandhi, frequently figure in the titles of books on them. The same holds true for Ashoka: scores of books carry his name on their title pages: *Asoka* (Bhandarkar, 1925), *Asoka, the Righteous: A Definitive Biography* (Guruge, 1993), *Asoka* (Mookerji, 1928), *Asoka and the Decline of the Mauryas* (Thapar, 1961), *Asoka—The King and the Man* (Thaplyal, 2012), *Ashoka* (Allen, 2012), and *Asoka as Depicted in his Edicts* (Hazra, 2007) are a few such. For a detailed bibliography on Ashoka, Falk (2006).

28. This is evident from the handful of books on them, as compared to the scores of writings on Ashoka. For Samudragupta, Gokhale (1962); for Chandragupta, Mookerji (1952); for a recent study of Didda, see the relevant chapters in Rangachari (2009).

29. Hinghausen (1966), Mookerji (1926), Devahuti (1970), Sharma (1970), S.R. Goyal (1986), and S. Goyal (2006).

30. Guha (2004): 246. Ramachandra Guha himself has written the biographies of Verrier Elwin (1999) and Mahatma Gandhi (2013), apart from essays on a range of scientists, statesmen, academics, and litterateurs.

31. The historian of Buddhism T.W. Rhys Davids describes Ashoka as one of the most striking and interesting personalities in world history because of his simple, sane, and tolerant view of conduct and life, a man who was 'free from all the superstitions that dominated so many minds, then as now, in East and West alike.' See Rhys Davids (1903): 306.

32. Among scholars Romila Thapar, more than fifty years ago, stated this with greater clarity than most. It was widely felt, she said, that 'a long political tradition beginning with Asoka, of conscious non-violence and a toleration of all beliefs political and religious, continued unbroken through the centuries culminating in the political philosophy of Gandhi'. Thapar (1961): 214.